PROPAGANDA

Propaganda is the next effective weapon used by the states after diplomacy in conducting their foreign relations. It is completely different from the diplomacy in essence and style. Propaganda is more like a *psychological warfare* targeted at specific groups. It is usually an attempt to persuade or influence leaders as well as the general population of other countries. Since propaganda is generally directed at the enemy or those who are hostile, it involves the manipulation of facts and symbols to attain the desired effects on the minds of an audience. Therefore, some scholars consider the term 'propaganda' to be too narrow and only a part of *psychological methods* of conducting international relations. Scholars like W.P. Davison (1963) prefer to use the term 'political communication' in its place. Whatever one calls this method, it is undoubtedly true that this particular method was and is being continuously used by governments to realize their objectives.[26]

Holsti points out to the fact that due to the widespread involvement of average citizens or subjects in foreign affairs and increasing people-to-people contact between different nationalities, the psychological and public opinion factors have now come to play a decisive role in the conduct of foreign policy. The American involvement in the Vietnam War witnessing a massive loss of lives of American soldiers had a definite impact on the minds of the American people, which got reflected in the ensuing Presidential elections. The minds of people have evolved as an essential element in international relations. It is hard to ignore public opinion, either domestic or worldwide. Therefore, one of the unique aspects of modern international political relationships "is the deliberate attempt by governments, through diplomats and propagandists, to influence the attitudes and behaviour of foreign populations, or of specific ethnic, class, religious, economic, or language groups within those populations" with the aim that these foreign groups or the entire population will influence and mould the attitudes of their domestic government as desired by the propagandists. The aim is "to create a favourable image of their country abroad".[27]